(***Advaita-Vedanta***), but also distanced from other theistic forms of ***Vedanta*** such as ***Ramanuja***'s ***Vishishta-advaita*** that posits links between God and the world of conscious and non-conscious entities.

Each individual entity possesses a uniquely individuating feature (***vishesha***). According to ***Ramanuja***, all released souls have the same qualities. This raises a problem, the problem of differentiation. *Madhva* avoids this difficulty by positing a distinguishing factor other than ***karma***.

There are three categories of souls: those who are liberated; possible candidates for liberation; those who are beyond salvation. Liberation consists in the realisation of a state of innate consciousness and bliss focused on the divinity and is unattainable without a combination of devotion (*bhakti*) and divine favour (*prasada*).

Exceptionally for a *Vedantin* but consistently with his dualistic emphasis, while accepting that God is the efficient cause of the universe, *Madhva* denies that he is also its material or substrative cause. The material cause (*prakriti*) is an eternal reality that is distinct from God while dependent upon God. He excites its transformation into the cosmos.

Further reading: Mesquita 2000; Sarma 2003; Sharma 1986

Madhyamaka Buddhism: the 'middle way' school of *Mahayana* Buddhism founded by ***Nagarjuna*** (c. 150 CE). The school divided into *Prasangikas*, who thought that the philosopher should not put forward any positive arguments but rest content with destroying those of the opponent, and the *Svatantrikas*, who accepted that arguments should be advanced in favour of the tenet that nothing whatsoever has a permanent identity or essence. Prominent thinkers of the former school include: *Buddhapalita*